

WA.4 Where to File Directory

The offices a Washington owner-builder deals with — there are more of them than in most states — how to find each one for your parcel, and a page to write down what you confirmed.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Washington's building code is written by the State and enforced locally by 39 counties and hundreds of cities and towns, each with its own forms and fees — and your electrical permit may come from a different agency altogether. Confirm every item with the department that will issue your permit before you rely on it.

FOUR AGENCIES, ONE HOUSE

The building code is statewide; permits are not issued by the State — except the electrical one, which usually is. That inversion is the whole reason this document exists. Before you gather a single form, settle which four offices are yours.

Who issues what

Permit or approval	Who handles it	Agency
Building, plumbing, mechanical	City or town if your parcel is inside the limits; otherwise the county. This office issues the permit, reviews the plans, and calls most of your inspections.	City or county
Electrical	Labor & Industries, statewide — unless you are inside an incorporated city or town that runs its own electrical program, in which case that city does. Counties cannot.	L&I or city
On-site sewage, and often well siting	Your local health jurisdiction: a county health department, or a multi-county health district. Frequently not the same agency as your building department, and often not in the same building.	Local health
Water availability	A water purveyor's letter, an Ecology water right, or a permit-exempt well under the rules for your water resource inventory area. Your building department will not issue without this evidence.	Purveyor or Ecology

Settle the electrical question first

Two calls, ten minutes, and it decides who you deal with for the rest of the job. **First**, confirm whether your parcel is inside city or town limits or in unincorporated county — your county assessor's parcel lookup will tell you. **Second**, if you are inside a city, ask that city directly whether it runs its own electrical inspection program. If it does not, or if you are in unincorporated county, your electrical permit and inspections come from L&I.

Getting this wrong does not merely waste a phone call — it means nobody inspects your rough-in before you cover it. (RCW 19.28.010(3), (4); RCW 19.28.101(1))

HOW TO FIND EACH OFFICE

Finding the right office for your parcel

Office	How to find it
Building department (permit, plan review, most inspections)	Search "[your county] WA building permit" or "[your city] WA permits." Nearly every Washington jurisdiction now runs an online permit portal — ask which one and register before you file, not on filing day.
L&I electrical (permit, inspection, contractor and electrician lookup)	lni.wa.gov → Licensing & Permits → Electrical. Permits and inspection requests are handled online. Verify any contractor or electrician at secure.lni.wa.gov/verify/ .
Local health jurisdiction (septic, often wells)	The Department of Health publishes the authoritative list of every local health jurisdiction in the state at doh.wa.gov → About Us → Washington's Public Health System → Local Health Jurisdictions. Use that rather than guessing — several counties share a district.
Water availability	If you will connect to a public system, ask the purveyor for a written letter stating the ability to serve. If you will drill, start at ecology.wa.gov → Water & Shorelines → Water Supply → Water Availability, and find your water resource inventory area before you budget anything.
Planning / zoning and critical areas	Often a separate counter from building, sometimes the same one. Ask who confirms zoning, setbacks, and whether any critical area or shoreline designation touches your parcel — you need that answer before plan review, not during it.
Road approach	If your driveway meets a state highway , the access permit comes from WSDOT — wsdot.wa.gov . If it meets a county or city road, it comes from that road authority. Establish which road you are actually connecting to first.

STATE-LEVEL CONTACTS

These are stable and worth knowing. Phone numbers are left for you to write in — a wrong number printed in a kit is worse than no number.

State agencies and what each is actually for

Agency	Why you would contact them	Website
Labor & Industries (L&I)	Contractor registration and the public verification lookup; electrician certification; and — for most of the state — your electrical permit and electrical inspections.	lni.wa.gov
State Building Code Council	Publishes the Washington State Building Code, the state amendments, and the wildland-urban interface and tsunami map resources. Also where a local residential amendment must be approved.	sbcc.wa.gov
Department of Ecology	Water rights and water availability, water resource inventory areas, well construction under chapter 18.104 RCW, and the construction stormwater permit.	ecology.wa.gov
Department of Health	Writes the on-site sewage rule (chapter 246-272A WAC) that your local health jurisdiction administers, and publishes the directory of those jurisdictions.	doh.wa.gov
Department of Revenue	Retail sales tax on construction — see WA.5. Also the sales tax rate lookup for your exact address.	dor.wa.gov
Department of Natural Resources	The statewide wildfire hazard map that the wildland-urban interface provisions key to.	dnr.wa.gov
Washington State Legislature	The RCW and WAC text itself — every citation in this kit can be read here in about a minute.	app.leg.wa.gov

HIGH-VOLUME COUNTIES — VERIFIED DOMAINS

The domain is the durable key; navigate from the home page rather than trusting a deep link. Where the health jurisdiction is a separate organization with its own domain, it is given — that separation is exactly the thing owner-builders miss.

County domains, checked live August 2026

County	County site	Local health jurisdiction
King	kingcounty.gov	kingcounty.gov (Public Health — Seattle & King County)
Pierce	piercecountywa.gov	tpchd.org (Tacoma-Pierce County Health Department)
Snohomish	snohomishcountywa.gov	snohd.org (Snohomish County Health Department)
Spokane	spokanecounty.gov	srhd.org (Spokane Regional Health District)
Clark	clark.wa.gov	clark.wa.gov (Clark County Public Health)

County domains, checked live August 2026

County	County site	Local health jurisdiction
Thurston	thurstoncountywa.gov	thurstoncountywa.gov
Kitsap	kitsap.gov	kitsappublichealth.org (Kitsap Public Health District)
Yakima	yakimacounty.us	via the DOH directory
Whatcom	whatcomcounty.us	whatcomcounty.us
Benton	bentoncountywa.gov	bfhd.wa.gov (Benton-Franklin Health District)
Franklin	franklincountywa.gov	bfhd.wa.gov (Benton-Franklin Health District)
Skagit	skagitcounty.net	skagitcounty.net
Island	islandcountywa.gov	islandcountywa.gov
Lewis	lewiscountywa.gov	lewiscountywa.gov

Each domain above was requested and returned a live Washington government site in August 2026; **department names and page paths inside those sites were not all separately verified**, so navigate from the home page. Not in the table? Two statewide directories cover the rest: local health jurisdictions at **doh.wa.gov**, and building departments through the Washington Association of Building Officials at **wabo.org** — a professional association, not a government agency. **mrsc.org** (Municipal Research and Services Center) is the standard reference for Washington local government and is likewise non-governmental.

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Confirm each entry by speaking to the office rather than copying it from a search result, and write the date you confirmed it. Note the name of the person you spoke to — in a permit office, having a name is worth more than having a number.

BUILDING DEPARTMENT — issues the permit; most inspections

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ELECTRICAL — L&I OR CITY — circle which; permit and inspections

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

PLANNING / ZONING — setbacks, critical areas, address assignment

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

LOCAL HEALTH JURISDICTION — on-site sewage; often well siting

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

WATER — PURVEYOR OR ECOLOGY — evidence of adequate supply

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ROAD AUTHORITY — driveway approach — WSDOT, county, or city

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ELECTRIC UTILITY — temporary construction power and permanent service

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ENERGY TESTING AGENCY — blower door, duct, ventilation — book early

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

Sources (verified August 2026 at app.leg.wa.gov): the state building code is in effect in all counties and cities — RCW 19.27.031(1); electrical is regulated by chapter 296-46B WAC or the local jurisdiction's electrical code — WAC 51-51-003; L&I inspects electrical work and only cities and towns may legislate in the field — RCW 19.28.101(1) with RCW 19.28.010(3), (4); on-site sewage is permitted by the local health officer — WAC 246-272A-0200(2); evidence of an adequate water supply is a condition of the building permit — RCW 19.27.097(1).